Comparing Lengths

Parent guide: use equal-sized units

Try one activity at a time for 5-10 minutes.

Your child should be able to count up to 8.

Read the instructions aloud. Spoken answers are welcome.

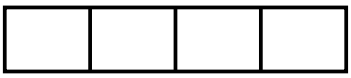
You need a pencil. No ruler or cutting is needed.

Model it together

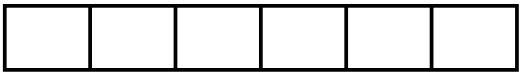
Each small box is one unit. All the boxes are the same size.

Count the boxes, not the dividing lines.

A



B



A is 4 units long. B is 6 units long.

B is longer than A. A is shorter than B.

The left ends line up so the lengths are easy to compare.

Help without giving the answer

Ask: "Where does it start? Where does it end?"

Ask: "Can you touch each box once as you count?"

If counting is tricky, compare the aligned ends first.

When measuring with objects, use equal-sized units placed end to end, with no gaps or overlaps. These are units, not cm.

Print pages 2-3 on A4, preferably at actual size.

Black-and-white printing is suitable. Answers are on page 4.

1. Compare the strips

The left ends line up. Look at where each strip ends.

Circle A or B for questions 1-3; Yes or No for question 4.

1. Which strip is longer? A / B

A

B

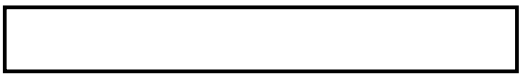
2. Which strip is shorter? A / B

A

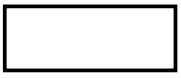
B

3. Which strip is longer? A / B

A



B



4. Are these strips the same length? Yes / No

A

B

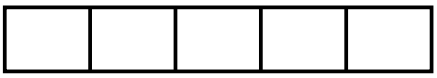
2. Count equal units

Each small box is one unit. Count the boxes in each strip.

Write or say how many units long each strip is.

A

A is _____ units long.

B 

B is _____ units long.

C

C is _____ units long.

D

D is _____ units long.

Now compare

1. Which strip is the longest? _____
2. Which strip is the shortest? _____
3. How many units longer is B than A? _____

Explain: How did the boxes help you compare?

Answers and next steps

Page 2: Compare the strips

1. B is longer.
2. B is shorter.
3. A is longer.
4. Yes. A and B are the same length.

Page 3: Count equal units

A = 3 units B = 5 units C = 8 units D = 6 units

1. C is the longest.
2. A is the shortest.
3. B is 2 units longer than A: 5 - 3 = 2.

Possible explanation: each box is the same size, so more boxes in a row make a longer strip. Other clear explanations are welcome.

A short hands-on follow-up

Draw two straight strips with their left ends lined up.
Ask your child to point to the longer and shorter strip.
Then draw a pair that are the same length.
Optional stretch: ask your child to draw a strip 7 boxes long and one 5 boxes long using equal-sized boxes in a row.
How much longer is the first strip? Answer: 2 units.

Notice whether your child compares length rather than width, counts each unit once and uses the same-sized unit throughout. Repeat with fewer boxes if needed; there is no timed target.